

**Regional Committee for the
Eastern Mediterranean
Seventy-third session
Pre-session virtual event
28 September–1 October 2026**

September/October 2026

Shaping the future of digital health and health information systems in the Eastern Mediterranean Region: progress, partners and the path ahead

Date: Tuesday, 29 September 2026

Time: 11:00–12:30 (Cairo time)

Duration: 90 minutes

Modality: Virtual (Zoom calendar invite to be sent by email)

Objectives

On 29 September 2026, a virtual event on shaping the future of digital health and health information systems in the Eastern Mediterranean Region: progress, partners and the path ahead will be held during the virtual week preceding the 73rd session of the WHO Regional Committee for the Eastern Mediterranean.

The objectives of the event are to:

- review progress in implementing the regional strategy for fostering digital health in the Eastern Mediterranean Region (2023–2027) and the regional strategy for enhancing and digitalizing health information systems (2024–2028), highlighting key milestones and country-level advancements;
- identify persistent challenges and gaps in digital health governance, digitalization of health information systems, interoperability, capacity-building, and governance of artificial intelligence (AI) across the Region, and discuss strategies for addressing them; and
- explore opportunities for regional collaboration and knowledge-sharing to accelerate digital health transformation and strengthen health information systems, including the integration of AI safely, ethically and equitably.

Background

AI holds immense scope to transform global health and improve equitable health outcomes, as affirmed by the Seventy-seventh World Health Assembly in May 2024 and in subsequent resolutions of the WHO Regional Committee for the Eastern Mediterranean. These include the regional strategy for fostering digital health in the Eastern Mediterranean Region (2023–2027), endorsed in resolution EM/RC69/R.6 (2022), and the regional strategy for the enhancement and digitalization of health information systems in the countries of the Eastern Mediterranean Region (2024–2028), endorsed in resolution EM/RC71/R.6 (2024).

The aim of the regional strategy for fostering digital health in the Eastern Mediterranean Region (2023–2027) is to improve health outcomes through sustainable, standards-based infrastructure and solutions aligned with national digital health priorities. It advances four strategic objectives: strengthening digital health governance, norms and standards at regional, national and subnational levels; advocating for people-centred digital health systems and networks appropriate to their regional and national context; advancing the development, implementation and evaluation of national digital health strategies, consistent with digital health maturity and linked to advancing national capacities and digital health literacy; and promoting regional and national stakeholder collaboration towards advancing digital transformation, knowledge translation and innovation.

Building on this foundation, the regional strategy for the enhancement and digitalization of health information systems in the countries of the Eastern Mediterranean Region (2024–2028) addresses critical challenges

facing national health information systems, which remain fragmented, incomplete and of poor quality in many countries, limiting effective planning and decision-making. The strategy has four strategic goals: to develop national health information strategies and plans and enhance governance and partnership mechanisms; to invest in infrastructure and secure the necessary human and financial resources required for a sustainable health information system; to promote interoperability of the health information system and implement data standards for health care settings and related information systems; and to identify inequities and promote data use in decision-making.

Both resolutions requested the Regional Director, *inter alia*, to report on progress in their implementation. Progress reports will be therefore presented to the Regional Committee at its 73rd session in October 2026 (see documents EM/RC73/INF.DOC.11 and EM/RC73/INF.DOC.16). This event will serve as a preparatory platform to review progress, discuss challenges, and inform the way forward for digital health and digitalization of health information systems in the Region, while also addressing the emerging use of AI in health care, which will be examined further during the WHO side-event on AI for health, scheduled to take place during the 73rd session of the Regional Committee.

Expected outcomes

- Comprehensive understanding of progress achieved across the Region in digital health and digitalization of health information systems, including country-specific advancements in national strategies, governance structures, tools and infrastructure development.
- Practical insights on addressing key challenges, including fragmentation, interoperability gaps, workforce capacity and AI governance, and on actionable strategies applicable to national contexts.
- Enhanced awareness of regional collaboration mechanisms and how Member States can leverage these platforms to share best practices and develop solutions.
- Clarity on the way forward for AI integration in health systems, including the need for robust governance frameworks, ethical guidelines and capacity-building initiatives.